

Scenario Pack — Image Ethics in Crime & Justice

Discussion scenarios with model responses *By Tara Abrahams and Scott Jacques · Supported by [CrimRxiv Consortium \(https://www.crimrxiv.com/\)](https://www.crimrxiv.com/) · CC BY 4.0.*

These scenarios are designed for newsroom training, police academy and in-service sessions, journalism and criminal justice classrooms, and community discussions. They are realistic composites drawn from documented cases and current research. They are not legal advice.

Each scenario presents a situation, three to five discussion questions, and a model response that reflects current best practice and peer-reviewed evidence. There is rarely one right answer—use these to surface tradeoffs, not to settle them.

Scenario 1 — A circulating bystander video before facts are confirmed

Situation. A 38-second cell-phone video appears on a major social platform showing what looks like a police officer striking a person on a sidewalk. The clip is captioned with the city's name and is racking up hundreds of thousands of shares within an hour. Your newsroom (or your community page) is being asked to "post it now."

Discussion questions. 1. What can be verified within the first hour, and what must wait? 2. How would you frame the post if you decided to share it? 3. What harms could come from posting it now? From not posting it? 4. What is the original recorder owed before publication?

Model response. Slow down. Within the first hour, verify uploader, location, and date through reverse-image search and basic metadata inspection ([Silverman, 2026 \(https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=NfHEe39AMn4\)](#)). Try to obtain a longer version. Contact the agency for the corresponding BWC clip and any incident report. If you publish before verification, label clearly: "Unverified video circulating online appears

to show..." and note what is *not* known. Credit the original recorder where they have not asked for anonymity. If verification fails after a defined window, do not publish; explain that decision publicly if asked.

Scenario 2 — A use-of-force BWC video the agency wants to release in a 12-second cut

Situation. A police agency plans to release body-worn camera footage of a fatal officer-involved shooting. The agency's draft public release is a 12-second clip starting one second before the first shot. You—an internal review board member, a journalist, or an advocate—are asked to weigh in.

Discussion questions. 1. What does the 12-second cut leave out, and why does that matter? 2. What does the research say about how viewers will interpret the clip? 3. What would a more responsible release look like? 4. What should accompany the release in writing?

Model response. Push for release of the full sequence from activation through post-incident scene control, plus any pre-incident dispatch audio that informed the officer's approach. The 12-second cut amplifies the most ambiguous and most charged seconds without context, and the research is now clear that the same clip will be read very differently by different viewers (Cross et al., 2025 (<https://doi.apa.org/doi/10.1037/lhb0000642>); Park et al., 2024 (<https://onlinelibrary.wiley.com/doi/10.1002/acp.70007>)). Recent jurisdictional standards—such as the NYPD's 30-day release rule for critical incidents (<https://www.police1.com/law-enforcement-policies/nypd-tightens-bodycam-policy-to-30-day-release-of-most-critical-incident-videos>)—favor structured, full-context release. Pair the video with a written statement listing what is visible, what is not visible, and what is still under investigation. Notify the family before public release.

Scenario 3 — A photo of a grieving parent at a vigil

Situation. A photographer at a candlelight vigil for a child killed in a shooting captures a powerful image of the surviving parent in tears. The image is the most

compelling photo of the night. The parent did not refuse to be photographed but was clearly not aware in the moment.

Discussion questions. 1. Is "didn't refuse" the same as consent for publication? 2. What public interest is served by this specific image, beyond emotion? 3. Are there alternatives that honor the family without intruding? 4. What should the caption say?

Model response. Treat absence of refusal as a low bar. Try to reach the parent or family the next day to seek explicit permission for publication and to share the intended caption and use. The 2025 OVC media guidance (<https://ovc.ojp.gov/nvcrw2025/working-with-media/advocating-with-news-media>) urges photographers to favor images of resilience over images of peak grief, and to avoid publishing victims in distress when alternatives exist. If publication proceeds without consent because of a clear and overriding public interest, document the editorial reasoning and be ready to explain it.

Scenario 4 — A suspected AI-generated "crime scene" image

Situation. During a fast-moving story about a major fire that police now suspect was arson, a striking aerial photo of the scene begins circulating with attribution to a freelance photographer. It looks compelling, but the rooflines and shadows are slightly off, and no metadata is available.

Discussion questions. 1. What verification steps are non-negotiable? 2. What policy should govern AI-generated or AI-altered visuals in your newsroom or feed? 3. If you publish and it later turns out to be synthetic, what is the proper correction?

Model response. Verify the photographer's identity through prior published work and direct contact. Ask for the original file with embedded metadata. Run reverse-image search across multiple engines and check for prior appearances. If verification cannot be completed, do not publish; an unverified striking image is exactly the profile of a synthetic insertion. If a synthetic image slips through, the SPJ-aligned 2025 guidance (<https://thespjnews.org/2025/10/17/truth-and-empathy-guide-photojournalism-ethics/>) is clear: publish a labeled correction stating exactly what was AI-generated, take the image offline, and review newsroom policy.

Scenario 5 — A First Amendment auditor at the station lobby

Situation. A person walks into the lobby of a police station, openly carrying a camera, and begins recording the front desk and posted notices. They identify themselves as a "First Amendment auditor." A desk officer asks them to stop or to leave.

Discussion questions. 1. What rights does the recorder have in this space? 2. What rights does the agency have to set rules? 3. What is the line between an enforceable restriction and an unconstitutional one? 4. How should the officer document the encounter?

Model response. In most U.S. jurisdictions, members of the public have a First Amendment right to record in publicly accessible portions of government buildings (Justia summary (<https://www.justia.com/criminal/procedure/right-to-record-police-officers/>); Hall Booth Smith analysis (<https://hallboothsmith.com/citizen-video-audits-know-their-rights-and-yours/>)). The agency may post and enforce neutral rules (no entry beyond a marked line, no recording of secure work areas, no obstruction of public business) but cannot order someone to stop recording the lobby itself simply because they are recording. The desk officer should remain calm, restate any specific access rule that applies, document the interaction (often on the agency's own BWC if policy permits), and avoid escalation. An arrest predicated on the recording itself is highly likely to be challenged.

Scenario 6 — A domestic and family violence call captured on BWC

Situation. Officers respond to a domestic disturbance. By the time they arrive, the alleged perpetrator is calm and the victim is visibly upset, raising her voice. The BWC captures only this state. The footage is later considered as evidence and may be released in legal proceedings.

Discussion questions. 1. What does this footage capture, and what does it inevitably miss? 2. How should officers, prosecutors, and reviewers weight this footage against other evidence? 3. What risks does the footage create for the victim?

Model response. As Iliadis and Harris (2024) (<https://www.aic.gov.au/crg/reports/crg-3520-21>) and Harris (2020) (<https://www.tandfonline.com/doi/full/10.1080/10345329.2020.1831730>) have shown, BWC footage in domestic and family violence cases captures an incident-bounded slice of an ongoing pattern. It can validate the victim's experience, but it can also be used by perpetrators—who may present as calm to the camera—to cast doubt on the victim and even contribute to misidentification of the primary aggressor. Officers should explicitly contextualize what the footage shows and what they observed before activation. Prosecutors and reviewers should treat the footage as one input alongside history, statements, injuries, and patterns, not as a stand-alone arbiter.

Scenario 7 — Republishing an old graphic image on the anniversary of a crime

Situation. It is the five-year anniversary of a notorious local murder. An editor proposes leading the anniversary piece with the same graphic crime-scene photo that ran originally.

Discussion questions. 1. What is the public interest served by republication—and is it different from the original publication? 2. What harms accrue with each republication? 3. What alternatives exist?

Model response. Republication is a separate ethical decision from initial publication, and the calculus rarely favors graphic imagery on anniversaries. The family bears a foreseeable, repeated harm; the public interest is usually well served by a less graphic image (a portrait, a memorial photo, a courtroom image) plus careful written reporting. If the graphic image is genuinely necessary—for example, because new evidence has changed the public understanding of the case—document the editorial reasoning and notify the family in advance.

Scenario 8 — Officer review of footage before writing a report

Situation. Following a use-of-force incident, the on-scene officer asks to review their BWC footage before writing the incident report. The agency's policy is silent on the point.

Discussion questions. 1. What does the research say about how review-before-report affects officer memory? 2. What are the arguments for and against allowing the review? 3. What policy options exist, and what are the tradeoffs?

Model response. Adams, MacDougall and Paterson (2020) (<https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC7743977/>) found "camera conformity": officers who reviewed footage before writing statements correctly removed errors but also excluded *true* details that the camera did not capture. This argues against a blanket pre-review rule. A common compromise is a two-step report: officers first write a memory-only narrative (sealed), then review footage and write a supplementary report noting what the footage clarifies, contradicts, or adds. Whatever the agency chooses, the policy should be explicit, applied uniformly, and disclosed.

Using this pack

These scenarios work best when participants: - Read the scenario, then the questions —pausing before the model response - Discuss in small groups and report out before consulting the cited sources - Compare their reasoning to current peer-reviewed research, not only to intuition

Updates to this pack are released quarterly by Tara Abrahams and Scott Jacques, supported by [CrimRxiv Consortium](https://www.crimrxiv.com/) (<https://www.crimrxiv.com/>).